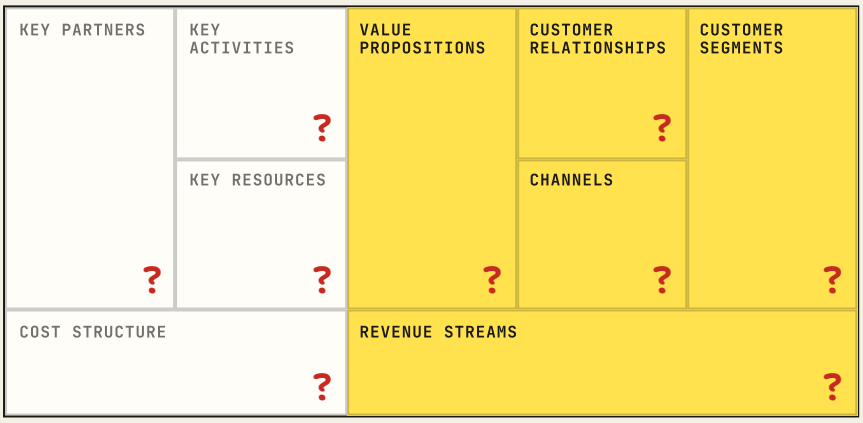
THE CANVAS INTERROGATION

Your canvas is a list of guesses.

A filled-in business model canvas looks like a plan, but every box is a belief nobody has tested yet. This sheet turns the nine boxes into sentences a stranger could prove wrong, finds the three that would sink you, and plans this week's cheapest test of each.

30 MINUTES | 6 PAGES | WORKS WITH ANY CANVAS | INCLUDES 5 HONEST AI PROMPTS



nine boxes, nine guesses. The yellow ones decide whether anyone wants it at all. Interrogate those first.

Layout after the Business Model Canvas by Strategyzer AG (CC BY-SA). The official blank canvas is free at strategyzer.com.

01 · INTERROGATE
Rewrite each box as a guess someone could disprove. (p.2)

02 · RANK
Plot the guesses by importance and evidence. Find your kill list. (p.3)

03 · TEST
Map one cheap test for each of your top three. (p.4)

04 · USE AI HONESTLY
Five prompts that find guesses instead of flattering them. (p.5)

FREE TO PRINT AND SHARE. KEEP THIS FOOTER.

Ask each box one hard question.

Write your guess as a sentence a stranger could prove wrong: `We believe [who] [does / has / will pay for what], because [what we've actually seen].` If the "because" is empty, that tells you something too.

BOX	THE QUESTION TO ASK IT	OUR GUESS, AS A SENTENCE SOMEONE COULD DISPROVE
WILL ANYONE WANT IT? · START HERE		
Customer segments WHO	Can I name three real people who had this problem in the last month?	
Value proposition WHY THEM	What do they do about it today, and what does that cost them?	
Channels HOW THEY FIND US	Where did the last person with this problem go looking for help?	
Customer relationships HOW WE KEEP THEM	Is this a one-off problem or a recurring one? How do I know?	
Revenue streams WHO PAYS, HOW	What have they already paid to solve it, and who signed off?	
CAN WE DELIVER IT? · THEN THESE		
Key activities WHAT WE MUST DO WELL	What's the one thing that, done badly, makes the rest pointless?	
Key resources WHAT WE NEED	What do we need that we don't yet have, and how sure are we we can get it?	
Key partners WHO WE DEPEND ON	Who would have to say yes, and have we asked them?	
CAN IT PAY? · THEN THIS		
Cost structure WHAT IT COSTS	What does it cost us to win and serve one customer? Is that a guess?	

Why this order? If nobody wants it, nothing else on the canvas matters, so test desirability ("will anyone want it?") before feasibility and viability. Number each guess 1–9 for the next page.

ORDER IS A RULE OF THUMB

Plot your nine guesses.

Write each guess's number on the map. **Up** = how badly the business breaks if it's wrong. **Right** = how much real evidence you have. Your kill list is the top-left: important guesses with no evidence behind them.

BREAKS THE BUSINESS ↑

KILL LIST · TEST THESE FIRST Important, and you're running on belief. Your top three go straight to page 4.	**KEEP WATCHING** Important, with some evidence. Re-check as you learn more.
PARK IT Unproven, but it won't sink you. Leave it alone for now.	**FINE FOR NOW** Low stakes and supported. Stop thinking about it.

LOW IMPORTANCE ↓

NO EVIDENCE → STRONG EVIDENCE

Prioritising by importance and evidence follows the assumptions-mapping approach in Bland & Osterwalder's *Testing Business Ideas*.

WHAT COUNTS AS EVIDENCE? SCORE HONESTLY BEFORE YOU PLOT

NONE	NONE	WEAK	GOOD	STRONG
A compliment "Love it!" costs them nothing.	**A forecast** "I'd use that", "people would pay".	**A past story** A specific time it happened to them.	**A workaround** Time or money they already spend on it.	**A commitment** Time, an intro, a deposit, now.

Your own conviction isn't on the ladder. Neither is your mum's.

One cheap test per guess.

FILL IN BEFORE YOU START

Decide what "wrong" looks like **before** you start. Writing the failure condition in advance is the whole trick, because afterwards you'll want to move the line.

KILL-LIST GUESS #1 · WE BELIEVE…

CHEAPEST TEST (≤ 7 DAYS, NO PRODUCT)	WHAT WE'LL COUNT
WE'RE WRONG IF…	RESULT · DATE

KILL-LIST GUESS #2 · WE BELIEVE…

CHEAPEST TEST (≤ 7 DAYS, NO PRODUCT)	WHAT WE'LL COUNT
WE'RE WRONG IF…	RESULT · DATE

KILL-LIST GUESS #3 · WE BELIEVE…

CHEAPEST TEST (≤ 7 DAYS, NO PRODUCT)	WHAT WE'LL COUNT
WE'RE WRONG IF…	RESULT · DATE

A STARTER MENU OF CHEAP TESTS

ILLUSTRATIVE · ROUGHLY CHEAPEST FIRST

Dig for workarounds
Search forums and reviews for people already hacking a fix or paying for one.

Five conversations
Past-behaviour interviews with people from your segment. See field sheets 01 & 03.

Do it by hand
Deliver the outcome manually for one or two people before you build anything.

A one-page offer
Describe it plainly with a clear ask, and count who takes the next step.

Ask for commitment
A deposit, letter of intent or intro. The strongest signal, and the scariest ask.

Does this way of working actually help? In a randomised trial, early-stage founders trained to frame ideas as hypotheses and test them dropped weak ideas sooner and earned more revenue than a control group. A larger replication also found benefits. Camuffo, Cordova, Gambardella & Spina, *Management Science* (2020); replication in *Strategic Management Journal* (2024).

Five prompts that find guesses instead of flattering them.

ILLUSTRATIVE · ADAPT FREELY

Chatbots are useful for spotting what you're assuming, and bad at telling you whether you're right. Ask the first kind of question, never the second. Paste your canvas from page 2 where it says […].

1	SURFACE THE GUESSES	Here is my business model canvas: […]. List every assumption hidden in it as a sentence that a stranger could prove false. Do not tell me whether the idea is good.
2	MAKE THEM FALSIFIABLE	For each assumption, describe what I would actually observe in the world if it were false. Be concrete: who does what, how often.
3	ARGUE THE OTHER SIDE	Act as a sceptical investor who has seen 500 ideas like this fail. Which three assumptions, if wrong, would end this business? Give the strongest case against each.
4	DESIGN THE CHEAPEST TEST	Design the cheapest test of this assumption that I can run in seven days without building a product: […]. State in advance the result that would mean I'm wrong.
5	CHECK YOUR QUESTIONS	Here are the questions I plan to ask in customer interviews: […]. Flag any that are leading, hypothetical, or mention my solution, and rewrite them to ask about specific past behaviour.

WHAT A CHATBOT CAN'T TELL YOU

Whether anyone will pay. Researchers who compared language-model answers with a real national survey found them similar on average, but analyses of the synthetic answers often reached different conclusions from the human data.

Bisbee et al. (2024), "Synthetic Replacements for Human Survey Data? The Perils of Large Language Models", *Political Analysis* 32.

Use AI to find guesses.
Use people to test them.
Never ask a chatbot if your idea is good.

Your assumption ledger.

Update this after every test and every conversation. A guess only changes status when a real person did or said something, and you write down who and when.

#	ASSUMPTION	STATUS	EVIDENCE: WHAT SOMEONE DID OR SAID	WHO · WHEN
1		○ UNTESTED ○ SUPPORTED ○ CONTRADICTED		
2		○ UNTESTED ○ SUPPORTED ○ CONTRADICTED		
3		○ UNTESTED ○ SUPPORTED ○ CONTRADICTED		
4		○ UNTESTED ○ SUPPORTED ○ CONTRADICTED		
5		○ UNTESTED ○ SUPPORTED ○ CONTRADICTED		

A contradicted assumption isn't a failure. It's the cheapest thing you'll learn all year.

PAPER DOESN'T ANSWER BACK

From scribble to evidence, without the theatre.

Unassumed does this loop with you. A note, voice memo or napkin photo becomes a first-pass canvas you can argue with. Every box becomes an assumption with a status. You rehearse the conversations that could break it against a synthetic customer who won't be led, then log what real people actually said. No idea score. No "validated" stamp. Just what has happened to each belief, who said it, and when.

Join the first cohort → unassumed.com